

The River Answers Back: The First Promise

河流的回应：第一次承诺

Theme: 环境、自然与可持续发展 · New: 44 · Review: 18 · Planned cumulative progress: 44/6, 127

English Story

The first promise was made while the water was still high, and it was almost too simple to be believed: the field station would measure the river from the north bank and the **east** bank at the same time. “A couple of gauges are not a system,” the director said, “but they are a step, and we need a step.”

The **natural** sciences had a different language from the local one, and the difference was nearly a gulf. “You bring me **ice** and **temperature** and a computer program,” a farmer said, “and I bring you an **ear** for what the water is doing.” The geologist agreed, and the two of them began to write the same list.

The **kit** was **odd** but **distinct**: a spade, a cage of **bamboo** for the bank, a permit for the **pit**, and a gentle hose that could **bake** nothing but mud. “**Contrary** to the report, the **tiger** and the **bee** are not the problem,” the farmer said. “The **weed** is.”

The **insight** that followed was **accidental**, and it was a matter of **soda** and **onion**: the samples had been taken from a picnic spot where the water was barely moving. A survivor of the last flood described the **swell** at the mouth of the drain, and the team wrote it down as a source.

The promise was to **breed** a small, **boring**, useful habit: one reading a day, at the same hour, from a vegetarian cook, a hen keeper, and a beekeeper, all of them equipped with the same cheap **kit**. “**Nutrient** levels and **shrimp** counts are fine,” the director said, “but the data has to come from the people who live on the bank.”

The **altitude** of the station explained nothing and the technology explained everything else. By the end of the week, the promise had a shape: five families, one form, and a register that nobody could quietly correct. The **essence** of it was **naturally boring**: a drink of water, a bowl of peas, and a pipe of **tobacco** were the farmer's whole diet. A deaf neighbour and a criminal record in one family made the map of the district stranger than a church or a god, and the new readings were similar to the ones from the **east** bank. A pop of static from the radio ended the meeting.

中文翻译

第一个承诺是在水位还很高的时候做出的，而且它几乎简单到令人难以置信：野外站将同时在北岸和东岸测量这条河。“一对水位计算不上一个系统，”主管说，“但它们是第一步，而我们需要一步。”

自然科学与本地语言不同，而这种差异几乎成了一道鸿沟。“你给我冰、温度和一套电脑程序，”一位农民说，“而我给你一只听懂水在做什么的耳朵。”地质学家同意了，两人开始写同一份清单。

装备古怪但各有不同：一把铲子、一个竹笼护岸、一份开挖坑的许可，以及一根只能把泥烤硬的温水管。“与报告相反，老虎和蜜蜂不是问题，”农民说，“杂草才是。”

随之而来的洞见是偶然的，而且与苏打水和洋葱有关：样本取自一处水面几乎不动的野餐地点。一位上次洪水的幸存者描述了排水口处的涌浪，团队把它作为一条来源记录了下来。

这个承诺是培育一个微小、无聊而又有用的习惯：每天同一时刻读一次数，由一位素食厨师、一位养母鸡的人和一位养蜂人来做，他们配备同样的廉价工具。“营养水平和虾的数量都很好，”主管说，“但数据必须来自住在岸边的人。”

站点的海拔什么也解释不了，而技术解释了其余的一切。到那一周结束时，这个承诺有了形状：五个家庭、一张表格，以及一份谁也无法悄悄修改的登记簿。它的本质天然就是无聊的：一杯水、一碗豌豆和一根烟斗，就是那位农民的全部饮食。一个聋邻居和一家人身上的犯罪记录，让这个片区的地图比一座教堂或一位神更奇怪，而新的读数与东岸的那些相似。收音机里一阵静电噪声结束了会议。

Core Vocabulary · 核心词汇

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
different 'dɪfərənt POS: a	a. 不同的; [机] 差动, 微分的, 差速器 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. unlike in nature or quality or form or degree; s. distinctly separate from the first; s. differing from all...
couple 'kʌpl POS: n	n. 对, 夫妇, 数个; vt. 使成双, 连接, 使成婚, 把...联系起来; vi. 结合, 成婚 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a pair who associate with one another; n. a pair of people who live together; n. a small indefinite number; n...
natural 'nætʃərəl POS: n	n. 白痴; a. 自然的, 自然界的, 本能的, 天然的, 物质的, 正常的, 原始的, 自然数的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. someone regarded as certain to succeed; n. a notation cancelling a previous sharp or flat; n. (craps) a first...
east i:st POS: n	n. 东方, 东; a. 东方的, 向东的; adv. 向东方, 朝东方 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the cardinal compass point that is at 90 degrees; n. the countries of Asia; n. the region of the United States...
ice aɪs POS: n	n. 冰, 冰淇淋, 糖衣, 冷若冰霜, 矜持, 贿赂; vt. 使结冰, 冰镇, 覆以糖衣; vi. 结冰 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. water frozen in the solid state; n. the frozen part of a body of water; n. diamonds; n. a frozen dessert with...
drink drɪŋk POS: n	n. 饮料, 酒; v. 喝, 喝酒 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a single serving of a beverage; n. the act of drinking alcoholic beverages to excess; n. any large deep body...
ear iə POS: n	n. 耳朵, 倾听, 听觉, 穗; vi. 抽穗 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the sense organ for hearing and equilibrium; n. good hearing; n. attention to what is said; n. fruiting spike...
temperature 'temprətʃə POS: n	n. 温度, 发烧, 热度; [化] 温度 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the degree of hotness or coldness of a body or environment (corresponding to its molecular activity); n. the...
criminal 'krɪmɪnəl POS: n	n. 罪犯, 犯人, 刑事; a. 犯了罪的, 刑事的, 有罪的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. someone who has committed a crime or has been legally convicted of a crime; s. guilty of crime or serious offense...
odd ɒd POS: a	a. 奇数的, 古怪的, 剩余的, 零散的, 各种各样的, 少量的; n. 奇特的事物, 怪人; [计] 奇数, 奇校验, 光数据数字转换器 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. not divisible by two; s. not easily explained; s. an indefinite quantity more than that specified; s. of the...
permit pə'mɪt POS: n	n. 许可证, 许可, 执照, 通行证; vt. 允许, 容许, 可能, 使放手做; vi. 容许, 给以机会, 提供可能 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. large game fish; found in waters of the West Indies; v. consent to, give permission
naturally 'nætʃərəli POS: adv	adv. 自然地, 以自然力, 天生地 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: r. as might be expected; r. according to nature; by natural means; without artificial help; r. through inherent...
pop pɒp POS: n	n. 砰然声, 枪击, 含气饮料, 流行音乐, 通俗艺术; a. 流行的, 热门的, 通俗的; vt. 使发出爆裂声, 开枪打, 突然伸出; v... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a sweet drink containing carbonated water and flavoring; n. a sharp explosive sound as from a gunshot or drum...
onion 'ʌnjən POS: n	n. 洋葱; vt. 因洋葱使掉泪 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the bulb of an onion plant; n. bulbous plant having hollow leaves cultivated worldwide for its rounded edible...
distinct dɪ'stɪŋkt POS: a	a. 清楚的, 显著的, 不同的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. (often followed by 'from') not alike; different in nature or quality; a. easy to perceive; especially clear...
gentle 'dʒentl POS: a	a. 温和的, 文雅的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. stroke soothingly; s. soft and mild; not harsh or stern or severe; s. having or showing a kindly or tender nature...
bake beɪk POS: vt	vt. 烘焙, 烤; vi. 烤面包; n. 烘焙, 烤 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. cook and make edible by putting in a hot oven; v. prepare with dry heat in an oven; v. be very hot, due to heat...
insight 'ɪnsaɪt POS: n	n. 察看, 洞察力, 见识; [医] 自知力, 洞察, 顿悟 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a feeling of understanding; n. the clear (and often sudden) understanding of a complex situation; n. grasp...
pit pɪt POS: n	n. 深坑, 矿井, 果核, 地窖, 深渊, 绝境, 陷阱; vt. 窖藏, 使凹下, 使有麻点, 去...之核, 使留疤痕, 使相斗, 使... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a sizeable hole (usually in the ground); n. a concavity in a surface (especially an anatomical depression); ...

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
deaf def POS: a	a. 聋的; [医] 聋的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. people who have severe hearing impairments; a. lacking or deprived of the sense of hearing wholly or in part...
tobacco tə'bakəu POS: n	n. 烟草, 香烟; [医] 烟草 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. leaves of the tobacco plant dried and prepared for smoking or ingestion; n. aromatic annual or perennial herb...
survivor sə'vaivə POS: n	n. 生还者, 幸存者; [法] 生还者, 生存者, 幸存者 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. one who lives through affliction; n. one who outlives another; n. an animal that survives in spite of adversity...
gulf gʌlf POS: n	n. 海湾, 深渊, 漩涡, 隔阂; vt. 吞没 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an arm of a sea or ocean partly enclosed by land; larger than a bay; n. an unbridgeable disparity (as from)...
kit kit POS: n	n. 装备, 工具箱, 成套工具; [计] 成套部件; 成套零件 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a case for containing a set of articles; n. gear consisting of a set of articles or tools for a specified purpose...
essence 'esns POS: n	n. 实质, 本质, 香精; [化] 香精 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. any substance possessing to a high degree the predominant properties of a plant or drug or other natural product...
breed bri:d POS: n	n. 种类, 品种; v. 养育, 引起, 饲养, 繁殖 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a special variety of domesticated animals within a species; n. a special type; v. copulate with a female, use...
boring 'bo:riŋ POS: a	a. 烦人的, 无聊的, 无趣的; [机] 成孔期, 搪孔 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the act of drilling a hole in the earth in the hope of producing petroleum; s. so lacking in interest as to...
cage keidʒ POS: n	n. 笼, 牢房, 战俘营; vt. 关进笼内 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an enclosure made of wire or metal bars in which birds or animals can be kept; n. something that restricts...
shrimp ʃrɪmp POS: n	n. 虾, 小虾, 矮子; vi. 捕小虾 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. small slender-bodied chiefly marine decapod crustaceans with a long tail and single pair of pincers; many...
bee bi: POS: n	n. 蜜蜂, 聚会 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. any of numerous hairy-bodied insects including social and solitary species; n. a social gathering to carry...
weed wi:d POS: n	n. 杂草, 野草; vi. 除草; vt. 除...的草, 剔除 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. any plant that crowds out cultivated plants; n. a black band worn by a man (on the arm or hat) as a sign of...
contrary 'kɒntrəri POS: a	a. 相反的, 矛盾的, 对立的; n. 相反, 对立面; adv. 相反地 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. exact opposition; n. a logical relation such that two propositions are contraries if both cannot be true but...
tiger 'taɪgə POS: n	n. 老虎, 虎, 凶暴的人 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a fierce or audacious person; n. large feline of forests in most of Asia having a tawny coat with black stripes...
nutrient 'nju:triənt POS: a	a. 营养的, 滋养的; n. 营养物, 滋养物 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. any substance (such as a chemical element or inorganic compound) that can be taken in by a green plant and...
swell swel POS: n	n. 增大, 隆起的部分, 巨浪, 肿胀; a. 优秀的, 一流的; vi. 增大, 膨胀, 肿胀, 增强, 骄傲; vt. 使膨胀, 使增大, ... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the undulating movement of the surface of the open sea; n. a rounded elevation (especially one on an ocean)...
soda 'səʊdə POS: n	n. 苏打, 碳酸水; [化] 纯碱; 苏打; 碳酸钠 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a sodium salt of carbonic acid; used in making soap powders and glass and paper; n. a sweet drink containing...
pea pi: POS: n	n. 豌豆, 似豌豆的东西 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. seed of a pea plant used for food; n. the fruit or seed of a pea plant; n. a leguminous plant of the genus P...
picnic 'pɪknɪk POS: n	n. 野餐, 远足, 愉快的经历; vi. 去野餐, 远足 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. any informal meal eaten outside or on an excursion; v. eat alfresco, in the open air
hen hen POS: n	n. 母鸡, 雌禽 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. adult female chicken; n. adult female bird; n. flesh of an older chicken suitable for stewing; n. female of c...

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
altitude 'æltɪtju:d POS: n	n. 高度, 海拔, 高处; [电] 高度 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. elevation especially above sea level or above the earth's surface; n. the perpendicular distance from the b...
accidental ,æksɪ'dentl POS: a	a. 意外的, 偶然的, 非主要的, 附属的; n. 临时记号, 次要方面 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a musical notation that makes a note sharp or flat or natural although that is not part of the key signatu...
bamboo bæm'bu: POS: n	n. 竹子; [医] 竹类 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the hard woody stems of bamboo plants; used in construction and crafts and fishing poles; n. woody tropical...
spade speɪd POS: n	n. 铲子, 锄, 铲刀, 黑桃; vt. 以锄掘, 把...弄实抹平; vi. 铲 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a playing card in the major suit that has one or more black figures on it; n. a sturdy hand shovel that can...
vegetarian ,vedʒɪ'teəriən POS: n	n. 素食者, 食草动物; a. 素食的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. eater of fruits and grains and nuts; someone who eats no meat or fish or (often) any animal products